

**COCKPIT CLASS** A cadet being trained at Pioneer Flying Academy in Aligarh

earning an A. Schools have also moved up and down the table, which the government says is evidence of rankings starting to make a difference. "My core objective in introducing an FTO ranking system is to make pilot training more transparent and flying a more attractive career option for the youth," Naidu told INDIA TODAY. "Based on my interactions with aspiring cadets and their families, the idea was to institutionalise a system that brings clarity and conviction to their decision-making."

The government also wants FTOs to be more competitive internationally and retain cadets who currently go abroad for training. "We always talk about demand India is creating in aviation," says Naidu. "It is a very huge figure; we have around 1,700 aircraft on order, nearly 2X of the current fleet. These aircraft will need a skilled and safety-conscious workforce to fly them. We do not want to import the workforce to operate India's aviation growth. We want to train that workforce right here in India."

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> **K. RAM MOHAN NAIDU**
> *Union Civil Aviation Minister*



However, while industry has welcomed the initiative, having long flagged the need for India to be self-reliant in building its commercial pilot pipeline, a few FTOs are questioning the credibility of the whole exercise.

## THE SKILL GAP

Despite the aviation boom over the past decade, there is a 'skill gap' between the pilots India produces and those airlines can employ. "A fresh Commercial